

Haligric Research Integration Series

AINU

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*Indigenous People of Northern Japan -- Kamuy, the Iyomante, Yukar, and the Oldest Sacred Tradition
in the Japanese Archipelago*

The bear is not a symbol of the divine.

*The bear is a divine being who has put on a bear's body
to visit the human world and bring the gift of meat, fur, and relationship.*

*When the Ainu thank the bear for its visit,
they are thanking a kamuy who chose to come.*

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A Note on Sacred Knowledge and Ainu -- Sovereignty

The Ainu people have experienced centuries of suppression of their culture and sacred traditions, and many sacred practices were nearly lost. Contemporary Ainu communities are actively engaged in cultural revival and in specific decisions about what knowledge is appropriate to share publicly and what is held as community knowledge. This document presents what Ainu cultural organizations, scholars working with Ainu communities, and the Upopoy National Ainu Museum (opened 2020) have made publicly available. A further note on sourcing: Ainu religious knowledge was transmitted orally, and its documentation was shaped by outsiders — Japanese ethnographers and Western missionaries — whose framing was often colonial. Where the historical record is contested or where a detail could not be verified against Ainu-connected sources, this document says so plainly rather than filling the space with a plausible-sounding guess. Regional variation is real: practice in one kotan (community) was never identical to practice in another, and contemporary Ainu communities are the living authorities on their own tradition.

Introduction -- The Original People of Japan — Who the Ainu Are

The Ainu (the name means 'human' or 'person' in the Ainu language) are the indigenous people of northern Japan — specifically of Hokkaido (the northernmost major island of Japan), the Kuril Islands, and Sakhalin Island. Genetically and culturally distinct from the Japanese (Yamato) people, the Ainu represent a completely different cultural stream, descending from populations that inhabited the northern islands of Japan for at least 15,000 years before Japanese settlement began. They called their homeland Ainu Mosir — the land of the humans. The Ainu are one of the most underrepresented and most suppressed indigenous cultures in the world — their forced assimilation into Japanese culture beginning in the Meiji period (1868–1912) nearly destroyed their language, their ceremonial practices, and their cultural identity. Japan did not legally recognize the Ainu as an indigenous people until 2019. The Upopoy National Ainu Museum and Park opened in Hokkaido in 2020 — a direct acknowledgment of the cultural devastation and the necessity of recovery. **THE AINU — ESSENTIAL FACTS. GENETIC DISTINCTNESS:** DNA studies have confirmed that the Ainu are genetically distinct from the Japanese Yamato population — they descend substantially from the Jomon people, the prehistoric inhabitants of the Japanese archipelago (dating back at least 15,000 years). The Yamato Japanese descend primarily from the Yayoi people who migrated from the Asian mainland approximately 2,300 years ago. The Ainu's genetic heritage is among the most ancient in East Asia. **LANGUAGE:** The Ainu language is a language isolate — like the Tonkawa language of Texas, it has no demonstrated genealogical relationship to any other language family. Despite sharing the Japanese islands for centuries, Ainu has no genetic relationship to Japanese. The language was suppressed through the Meiji period and became critically endangered — contemporary estimates suggest fewer than ten fluent native speakers remain, though revitalization programs are producing new learners. **THE MEIJI SUPPRESSION:** Beginning in 1869, the Meiji government's colonization policies systematically dispossessed the Ainu of their lands, prohibited their traditional practices (including the iyomante bear ceremony, salmon fishing, and ceremonial tattooing), forced children into Japanese-language schools, and classified the Ainu as 'former aborigines' — a legal designation that denied their indigenous status. The cultural and demographic devastation was severe. **CONTEMPORARY AINU:** Government surveys have counted roughly 13,000 selfidentified Ainu in Hokkaido, and the commonly cited figure for self-identification nationwide is around 25,000 — though experts consistently estimate that the number of people with Ainu ancestry is far higher, because generations of discrimination taught families to conceal their identity. Cultural revival is actively underway — language revitalization programs, the reopening of traditional ceremonies, and legal

campaigns for the return of ancestral remains and sacred objects from Japanese and international collections.

Part One -- Ainu Identity: Genetic, Cultural, and Linguistic Distinctness

Ainu identity rests on three pillars of distinctness, each independently confirmed: genetics, language, and culture. **THE GENETIC EVIDENCE:** Population-genetic studies place the Ainu closest to the ancient Jomon inhabitants of the Japanese archipelago, whose presence dates back at least 15,000 years. The distinct Ainu culture recognizable in the archaeological record crystallized in Hokkaido around the 13th century, emerging from the earlier Satsumon culture with influences from the Okhotsk culture of the northern sea coasts. This matters: the Ainu are not 'Japanese who live differently.' They are the continuation of the archipelago's oldest population stream, with their own ethnogenesis, their own territory, and their own history of statecraft, trade, and war. **THE LINGUISTIC EVIDENCE:** Ainu is a language isolate. It is unrelated to Japanese, unrelated to the languages of Siberia, unrelated to anything demonstrable. It had no traditional writing system — the entire archive of the tradition was carried orally, in the epic song cycles (yukar), the songs of the gods (kamuy yukar), the prose tales (uwepeker), and the daily speech of the kotan. When the Meiji state banned the language from schools, it was attacking the tradition's entire storage medium at once. **THE CULTURAL EVIDENCE:** Everything in this document — the kamuy cosmology, the iyomante, the inaw, the yukar, the attush textiles, the tusu healing tradition — is distinct from Japanese Shinto and Buddhism. Points of resemblance (animism, reverence for natural sites) are the common inheritance of northern circumpolar cultures, with which the Ainu share far more: the bear ceremonialism of the Ainu belongs to the same circumpolar family of practice found among peoples across Siberia and northern North America, a family scholars call arctolatry — bear veneration. **AINUPURI — THE AINU WAY:** The Ainu term for their own way of life is ainupuri — 'Ainu customs.' Identity was never defined by blood alone but by practice: living rightly with the kamuy, observing the protocols, speaking the language, wearing the patterns. This is why cultural revival is not a nostalgia project. For the Ainu, recovering practice is recovering identity itself.

Part Two -- Ainu History: From Hokkaido Masters to Near-Extinction

MASTERS OF THE NORTH (13th–17th centuries): From their ethnogenesis around the 13th century, the Ainu were the masters of Hokkaido (which they called Ainu Mosir and the Japanese called Ezo), Sakhalin, and the Kuril Islands. They were not isolated huntergatherers: Ainu communities ran extensive trade networks connecting the Japanese mainland with Sakhalin, the Amur River peoples of the continent, and Kamchatka — trading salmon, furs, hawks, and continental goods. Ainu groups fought wars on Sakhalin against continental powers and maintained fortified hilltop compounds called casi (chashi) throughout Hokkaido. **FIRST BLOOD — KOSHAMAIN'S WAR (1457):** As Japanese (Wajin) traders and settlers established footholds on the southern tip of Hokkaido, friction turned to war. The Ainu leader Koshamain led a coalition against the Japanese settlements in 1457. The revolt was crushed, and the victors — the family that became the Matsumae clan — established themselves as the gatekeepers of the Japanese presence in Ezo. **THE MATSUMAE MONOPOLY AND SHAKUSHAIN'S WAR (1669):** Under the Tokugawa shogunate, the Matsumae clan held an exclusive monopoly on trade with the Ainu — a monopoly that grew steadily more exploitative as trading posts became instruments of control. In 1669 the Ainu leader Shakushain united historically rival Ainu groups in the largest coordinated resistance in Ainu history, attacking trading posts and shipping across Hokkaido. The revolt was ended by treachery: the Matsumae broke a truce and assassinated Shakushain and his retinue at what was presented as a peace banquet. It was the last large-

scale unified Ainu resistance. The place-contract system that followed forced Ainu communities into what amounted to bonded labor for Japanese merchant contractors. MENASHI-KUNASHIR (1789): The final armed rising came in 1789 in the Menashi district and Kunashir Island, when Ainu workers, brutalized by Japanese merchants, killed over seventy Japanese. The rising was suppressed, its leaders executed, and direct control tightened — driven in part by Japanese anxiety over Russian expansion from the north, which turned the Ainu homeland into a contested frontier between two empires. THE MEIJI ANNEXATION (1869): Following the Meiji Restoration, Japan unilaterally annexed the Ainu homeland in 1869, declared it effectively empty land, and renamed Ezo as Hokkaido. A colonization office (the Kaitakushi) flooded the island with Japanese settlers. The 1871 Family Registration Law classified the Ainu as 'former aborigines' and commoners of Japan; the same period brought bans on women's tattooing, men's earrings, and core religious practices. The Land Regulation Ordinance of 1872 appropriated Ainu land as state property. Salmon fishing — the center of the Ainu economy and diet — was criminalized as poaching in the rivers the Ainu had fished for centuries. Deer hunting was restricted as settler agriculture claimed the land. THE 1899 FORMER ABORIGINES PROTECTION ACT: The legal capstone of the assimilation project was the Hokkaido Former Aborigines Protection Act of 1899. Under the pretense of relieving Ainu poverty, it granted small, generally poor-quality farming plots (while the governor of Hokkaido retained administrative authority over them), forced a hunting-fishing-gathering people into agriculture, and pushed Ainu children into segregated Japanese-language schools where their own language was forbidden. The very title of the law — 'former aborigines' (kyu dojin) — wrote the erasure into legislation: the Ainu were to be treated as a people who no longer existed. The law remained in force for nearly a century. THE LONG REPEAL (1997): The 1899 Act was finally repealed in 1997 and replaced by the Ainu Cultural Promotion Act — a change driven by Ainu activism and by the landmark Nibutani Dam decision of the same year, in which the Sapporo District Court ruled that the government had illegally ignored Ainu culture in confiscating land for a dam in Nibutani, the heartland village of Ainu leader Kayano Shigeru — the first Ainu to sit in Japan's National Diet (1994-1998). The court's recognition that the Ainu were an indigenous people whose culture deserved legal consideration marked the turning of the tide, though the 1997 law itself was criticized for offering cultural promotion while conferring no indigenous rights.

Part Three -- The 2019 Recognition: Japan's Belated Acknowledgment

THE ROAD TO RECOGNITION: In 2007 the United Nations adopted the Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP), with Japan's support. In June 2008 — weeks before hosting a G8 summit in Hokkaido — both houses of Japan's Diet unanimously passed a resolution calling for the Ainu to be recognized as an indigenous people of Japan, and the government formally acknowledged them as indigenous for the first time, 140 years after annexing their homeland. THE 2019 AINU POLICY PROMOTION ACT: In April 2019 the Diet passed the Act on Promoting Measures to Realize a Society in Which the Pride of the Ainu People Is Respected — the first Japanese statute to name the Ainu as an indigenous people. The law prohibits discrimination against the Ainu, funds community and tourism development centered on Ainu culture, includes provisions easing the harvesting of forest products from state forests and salmon fishing for ceremonial purposes, and established the National Ainu Museum and Park — Upopoy — which opened at Shiraoi, Hokkaido, in July 2020. Upopoy means 'singing together in a large group.' WHAT THE RECOGNITION DID NOT DO: The 2019 Act confers recognition without rights. It contains no land rights, no self-determination, no hunting and fishing rights as inherent entitlements, no reparations, no apology, and no penalties for violations of its anti-discrimination clause. Ainu critics held a press conference before its passage calling for the bill's withdrawal on exactly these grounds, and scholars have documented that the law does not implement the UNDRIP standards Japan voted for. The Ainu remain among the few indigenous peoples in the world

with no land legally recognized as theirs. The fuller account of these criticisms — and of the ongoing legal battles over salmon rights and ancestral remains — is given in Parts Twenty-One and Twenty-Two. HOW TO HOLD THIS PART: 2019 was real and it was late, and it was both at once. Recognition matters: it changed what can be said in courtrooms, classrooms, and museums. And recognition without restitution is a beginning, not an arrival — which is precisely how the Ainu organizations pressing the government describe it.

Part Four -- AINU COSMOLOGY: Kamuy and the Sacred World

The Ainu sacred world is organized around the concept of kamuy — divine beings who inhabit and animate every significant element of the natural world. The Ainu universe is saturated with kamuy presence: every bear, every owl, every salmon, every fire, every water source, every wind carries or is governed by a specific kamuy whose relationship with the human community requires specific acknowledgment and ceremony. THE CREATION: In the creation account recorded from Ainu oral tradition, the world began as water and mud, unformed. The creator kamuy — Kotan-kar-kamuy, 'the one who made the world' — sent down a small bird, the water wagtail, to make the world habitable. The wagtail fluttered over the waters, beat the mud with its wings, stamped it with its feet, and packed it firm with its tail, until patches of dry land rose and floated on the ocean. This is why the Ainu word for the world is mosir — 'floating earth' — and why the wagtail is honored among birds. In some tellings the earth rests on the back of a great fish whose movements cause earthquakes. After the land was formed, other kamuy descended: the fire grandmother came down to give humans fire, and the culture-hero kamuy taught the people the skills of living. This is an earth-diver creation — the type in which the creator sends an animal down into the primordial waters — a form the Ainu share with peoples across Central Asia and Native North America. THE THREE WORLDS: Ainu cosmology distinguishes the world of the kamuy (kamuy mosir), the world of humans (ainu mosir), and the world below of the dead (pokna mosir). The crucial teaching: in kamuy mosir, the kamuy live like people, in human form, in villages of their own. When a kamuy visits the human world, it puts on a disguise — the body of a bear, an owl, a salmon, a fire. The animal body is called the kamuy's hayokpe, its armor or disguise. What humans see as an animal is a divine person wearing a costume in order to bring gifts. RAMAT — THE CURRENT OF SPIRIT: Beneath the whole system runs the concept of ramat — spirit, soul, vital energy. Everything significant carries ramat. Ceremony is, at its core, the correct management of ramat: receiving it gratefully when it arrives in the form of gifts, and sending it home correctly so that it will return. The entire ceremonial apparatus of the tradition — the prayer sticks, the libations, the sending ceremonies — is a technology for keeping the current of ramat flowing between the worlds. RECIPROCITY — THE OPERATING PRINCIPLE: The relationship between humans and kamuy is mutual and almost contractual. Humans owe the kamuy attention, gratitude, correct ceremony, and gifts the kamuy prize (inaw prayer sticks, wine, food). The kamuy owe humans protection, abundance, and honest dealing. A kamuy who behaves badly can be scolded, argued with, even formally rebuked — and a human community that behaves badly can expect scarcity. Neither side grovels. It is a relationship between persons.

Part Five -- Kamuy: The Divine Beings in Everything

WHAT KAMUY IS: Kamuy (sometimes written kamui) is the Ainu term for divine being or sacred presence — not in the abstract philosophical sense but in the immediate, specific, materially present sense. When the Ainu say that the bear is a kamuy, they do not mean that bears are symbols of the divine or that the divine is metaphorically expressed through bears. They mean that the specific bear in front of them is a divine being who has taken a bear's body in order to visit the human world and bring the gift of meat, fur, and relationship. WHAT COUNTS AS KAMUY: The Ainu recognized as kamuy the beings and forces that could genuinely help or harm human life: the significant animals (bear, owl, orca, salmon, deer, eagle, crane), the elemental presences (fire, water, wind, thunder, sun and moon), the

powers beyond human control (weather, disease), and even human-made implements of particular importance — boats, hearth hooks, mortars, treasured vessels — because anything made with deep sincerity was understood as being imbued with spirit and becoming a kamuy. What could neither help nor harm was generally not kamuy: the category tracks relationship, not mere existence. NOT ALL KAMUY ARE GOOD: The tradition is clear-eyed about this. There are helpful kamuy and there are wen kamuy — bad kamuy — including the kamuy of disease. The smallpox kamuy (payoka kamuy) comes to human villages to spread its illness. Such beings are not worshipped; they are managed — warded off, negotiated with, driven away with the help of protective kamuy and protective patterns. Ainu religion is not sentimental nature-worship. It is diplomacy across the whole range of powers that surround a human community, friendly and hostile alike. NO PRIESTHOOD, NO SCRIPTURE: The tradition has no professional priesthood and no scripture. The elder of the household or the respected elder (ekashi) of the community leads ceremony; the knowledge lives in memory, song, and practice. Every hearth is an altar, and the ordinary member of the community is a full participant in the sacred economy — which is why the tradition proved so hard to kill: it had no central institution to decapitate.

Part Six -- The Hierarchy of Kamuy: From Bear to Fire

KIM-UN KAMUY (THE BEAR — GOD OF THE MOUNTAINS): The most important and most powerful of the land kamuy — the divine being who governs the mountains and whose visits to the human world in bear form are the most significant single relationship in Ainu sacred life. The name means 'the kamuy of the mountains.' Part Eight is devoted to this being. KOTAN-KOR-KAMUY (THE GUARDIAN OWL): The kamuy of the village — the guardian divine being whose presence ensures the community's wellbeing. Blakiston's fish owl, the largest owl in the world, resident in the great river forests of Hokkaido, is this guardian kamuy in material form. Its watchful presence over the kotan made it the natural first song of Chiri Yukie's great collection (Part Twelve). Note the name: the guardian owl shares its title ('possessor of the village/world') with the creator, Kotan-karkamuy ('maker of the world') — two distinct beings whose similar names reflect their shared care for the inhabited world. APE-HUCI KAMUY (THE FIRE GRANDMOTHER): The fire kamuy — female, an elder, the single most important presence in daily religious life and by many accounts the most important female deity of the tradition. Every hearth fire is her physical presence. She stands at the boundary between the human and kamuy worlds and carries prayers to the other kamuy — when human prayers are insufficient or clumsy, she supplements them. She witnesses everything that happens in the house; she protects the family; the souls of newborns come through her fire, and the souls of the dead pass through it on their way to the next world. The fire is never insulted, never stepped over, never carelessly extinguished. Nearly every ceremony in the tradition begins by addressing her first. REPUN KAMUY (THE ORCA — GOD OF THE SEA): The killer whale, kamuy of the open sea, governing fishing, storms, and the sea's abundance. Coastal communities maintained specific ceremonial relationships with Repun Kamuy; a whale carcass driven ashore was received as this kamuy's deliberate gift, and orcas themselves were never hunted. CHUP KAMUY (SUN AND MOON): The heavenly kamuy of light and time — chup is the Ainu word for the sun and moon as luminaries, with the sun (the day chup) generally honored as the greater presence. (A note on sourcing: an earlier compilation of this material used the name 'Cipasir' for the sun and moon kamuy; that name could not be verified in the published literature on Ainu religion and has been replaced here by the well-attested terminology.) KANNA KAMUY (THUNDER): The kamuy of thunder and lightning, dwelling in the sky, sometimes described in serpent or dragon form. AE-OYNA KAMUY / OKIKURMI (THE CULTURE HERO): The kamuy who came down to the human world and taught the Ainu the arts of living — fire-making, weaving, carving, fishing, hunting, house-building, medicine, and the protocols of ceremony itself. He is called Ainurakkur — 'the one who smells of humanity,' the father of the Ainu — and appears in the epics under the names Okikurmi and Aeoina Kamuy. He is the tradition's bridge figure: divine enough to know how the kamuy world works, human enough

to teach it. WAKKA-US KAMUY (WATER): The kamuy of fresh water — rivers, springs, the drinking water on which every kotan depended. Water sources were kept scrupulously clean as a matter of religious law. AND EVERY SIGNIFICANT BEING: Salmon, deer, eagle, crane, fox, thunder, wind, specific mountains, specific implements — the Ainu understood every significant animal, every consequential natural phenomenon, and specific human-made objects of particular power as either being kamuy in material form or as governed by specific kamuy. The hierarchy above is the fixed constellation; the full population of the kamuy world is as large as the world itself.

Part Seven -- Charanke: Sacred Dispute Resolution and the World's Balance

THE PRACTICE: Charanke (also rendered caranke or carange) means, roughly, 'to let words fall' — a prolonged, formal, public debate. When a dispute arose — between individuals, between families, or between whole communities — the parties did not resort to violence and did not submit to a ruler's decree, because there was no ruler. They sat down and argued it out, at length, in formal oratory, before the community, until one side conceded or a settlement was reached. Disputes between kotan were decided on the merits in these open discussions, held in some accounts within the *casi*, the fortified compounds. The explicit purpose was to prevent disputes from escalating into violence. THE SKILL: Charanke was an endurance discipline as much as a rhetorical one. A skilled advocate had to hold genealogies, precedents, and the whole history of the dispute in memory, and deploy them in eloquent formal speech — sometimes across many hours or days. Verbal stamina, precision, and command of tradition decided outcomes. In a culture without writing, the great debaters were walking law libraries. THE LAW BENEATH IT: Charanke worked because it rested on a shared, binding customary law — norms governing hunting territories, fishing rights, marriage, compensation for injury. The point is documented from an unexpected direction: in 2024, the Sapporo District Court, reviewing the historical record in the Raporo Ainu Nation salmon case (Part Twenty-One), found that in the Edo period the salmon-fishing rights of each Ainu group — who could fish, where, when, and by what means — were defined and enforced by Ainu custom, binding both in disputes settled among Ainu groups themselves through charanke and in disputes mediated with the Matsumae domain. Alongside debate, tradition also preserved *saimon*, trial by ordeal, whose outcome constituted a binding settlement; and for wrongdoing within the community, the village leadership judged the matter openly. THE COSMOLOGICAL DIMENSION: Charanke was not limited to human parties. The tradition permits — expects — formal remonstrance with the kamuy themselves. A kamuy who fails its obligations, who sends disaster without cause, can be addressed in the same register: respectfully, firmly, at length, with the grievance laid out in order. The universe of the Ainu is a community of persons, and the instrument that keeps a community of persons in balance is not force. It is speech — sustained, formal, truthful speech. In the twentieth century, Ainu activists revived the word itself: to bring charanke to the Japanese state is to stand and argue one's rights, in public, at length, without violence and without surrender. The word for an ancient legal ritual became the word for the modern movement.

Part Eight -- THE BEAR KAMUY (KIM-UN KAMUY): The Most Important Sacred

Being The bear is not the Ainu totem. The bear is a kamuy — the master of the mountains — who comes to the human world wearing a bear's body as a disguise (*hayokpe*), carrying the gifts of meat and fur. In kamuy *mosir*, the bear kamuy lives in human form, in a house, in a village of kamuy. When it chooses to visit the human world, it puts on the bear body the way a traveler puts on a coat, and it chooses the hunter to whom it will give itself. A successful hunt is therefore not a conquest; it is a reception. The animal willed the encounter. This

inverts the entire Western frame. The hunter does not take; the kamuy gives. The meat and hide are not spoils; they are gifts the divine visitor leaves in exchange for the hospitality it receives. And hospitality is the operative word: the obligation created by the bear's gift is the obligation of a host to an honored guest — culminating, in the case of a cub raised in the community, in the most elaborate act of hospitality the tradition knows: the iyomante, the ceremony of sending the guest home. The relationship carries teeth in both directions. A bear that harms humans without cause is understood as a wen kamuy — a bad kamuy — and is dealt with as such; and a community that treats the bear's gifts carelessly can expect the mountains to close. The bear kamuy is the tradition's central test case of the reciprocity principle: the most powerful, most dangerous, most generous neighbor the human community has.

Part Nine -- THE IYOMANTE: The Bear Sending Ceremony — Complete Step-by-Step

The Iyomante (also spelled Iomante — from i-oman-te, 'to cause someone to go,' to send away, to send home) is the most important and most elaborate ceremony in the Ainu tradition — a multi-day ceremony in which a bear that has been raised by the community from a cub is ritually killed and its spirit (the bear kamuy) is sent back to the kamuy world with elaborate ceremony, gifts, and expressions of gratitude and love. Sending ceremonies as a class could be performed for other beings — the owl, the fox — and a simpler rite (opunire) was performed for bears taken wild in the hunt; the sending of lesser things, including worn-out tools whose spirits also required dispatch, is called iwakte. The iyomante of the raised cub is the summit of the whole system. UNDERSTANDING THE IYOMANTE CORRECTLY: Western accounts have often characterized it as 'bear sacrifice' — a frame that completely misses the ceremony's sacred logic. In Ainu understanding, the bear is not being killed; the bear kamuy is being liberated from its bear-body and sent home to the kamuy world. The bear was not born as an animal that will be killed — it is a divine being who chose to visit the human world in animal form to bring the specific gifts that bears bring. The ceremony is the community's act of love and gratitude toward the visiting divine being, and the elaborate sendinghome honors the kamuy so that it will tell the other kamuy of its welcome, and want to visit again. THE PREPARATION (ONE TO TWO YEARS BEFORE): A bear cub is found, traditionally in late winter or early spring — often after its mother has been taken in the hunt, the cub understood as a sacred charge received from the mother's spirit. The cub is brought to the kotan and raised within the community — kept in a stout cub cage (heperset), fed by community members, treated with affection; in the old accounts, very young cubs were sometimes nursed by women alongside their own infants. As the bear grows, it is the divine visitor who has been given the gift of a community childhood, addressed with respectful terms and spoken to with prayers. THE ANNOUNCEMENT: When the bear has matured sufficiently (typically around two years), the ceremony is announced. Guests from neighboring kotan are invited — an iyomante was a regional event. The women begin the great work of provisioning: brewing the ceremonial millet wine (tonoto) in large batches, preparing round dumplings (sito) — and the men whittle quantities of new inaw (prayer sticks, Part Ten) and prepare the altar. DAY ONE — STEP 1, THE GATHERING: Community and guests assemble. The ceremony ground is prepared: the outdoor altar (nusasan) — a fence-like row of tall inaw — is erected and hung with offerings, and the hearth is attended, because every stage of what follows is conducted in the witness of Apehuci, the fire grandmother, who will carry word of the community's conduct to the kamuy world. STEP 2 — THE PRAYERS TO THE BEAR: The presiding elder (ekashi) speaks directly to the bear — explaining what is about to happen, expressing the community's love for the kamuy who has lived among them, and asking the kamuy's glad cooperation in its own sending. These prayers are addressed to a person, not an animal: the bear can hear, understand, and answer. STEP 3 — THE SONGS AND DANCES: The community sings upopo (the seated communal songs, Part Fifteen) and dances rimse in a ring, building the ceremonial field. The bear is brought out, adorned, and — in the old accounts — walked in

procession and played with one last time, the community bidding farewell to the guest of honor. STEP 4 — THE SENDING: The bear is ritually killed. In the traditional ceremony the men first shoot blunt, decorated ceremonial arrows (hepere-ai, 'cub arrows') — understood as parting gifts, not weapons — before the actual sending, accomplished by the swiftest means the tradition knew: in most documented forms, the bear's neck was compressed between two logs while the community's prayers surged, so that the spirit would depart quickly and cleanly. The moment of death is the moment of liberation: the kamuy steps out of its disguise and turns toward home. The women's ritual weeping at this moment is documented and correct — grief and gratitude are not opposites here. STEP 5 — THE PRAYERS AT THE MOMENT OF SENDING: At the bear's death, the prayers speak the ceremony's whole purpose aloud: gratitude for the visit, the request for blessing on the community, and above all the request that the departing kamuy tell the other kamuy how well it was treated — so that more kamuy will choose to visit, which is to say, so that the mountains will keep giving. DAY TWO AND BEYOND — STEP 6, THE FEAST: The bear's meat is prepared and eaten communally — the food is the physical gift the kamuy brought from the sacred world, and eating it together is the community's reception of the blessing. Portions of the food and wine are set aside strictly for the kamuy and never touched by the people. STEP 7 — THE GIFTS: Specific gifts are assembled to accompany the kamuy home — inaw, food, wine, treasured implements — the freight of gratitude the spirit carries back as proof of its welcome. STEP 8 — THE SKULL IS HONORED: The bear's skull — the seat from which the spirit departs — is carefully prepared, decorated (in regional practice, adorned with inaw shavings, sometimes with ornaments, the sockets filled with curled inaw-kike), addressed with final prayers, and installed at the altar among the gifts, passed out of the house not through the door but through the sacred east-facing window (kamuy puyar, the spirit window) reserved for the traffic of the gods. STEP 9 — THE SENDING-HOME PRAYER: The final prayers speak directly to the departing kamuy: farewell; gratitude; the request to tell the others that this community is worthy of visits; and the invitation to return. The skull remains at the altar afterward, the visible record of a guest well sent. SUPPRESSION AND REVIVAL: The iyomante was suppressed under Meiji assimilation policy, and in 1955 the governor of Hokkaido issued a notice condemning it, driving the ceremony further underground; it was nonetheless carried on quietly by communities determined not to let the central rite of the tradition die. In 2007 the government formally withdrew the 1955 notice, acknowledging the ceremony's religious and cultural significance, and iyomante and other sending ceremonies are now practiced and taught openly — one of the clearest single markers of the tradition's survival.

Part Ten -- INAW: Sacred Prayer Sticks — The Medium of Communication

WHAT AN INAW IS: The inaw (also inau) is a stick of living wood — willow and dogwood are the classic materials — whittled so that long, fine, curling shavings (inawkike, 'shaving-flowers') remain attached, cascading from the shaft like blossom or hair. Inaw are erected wherever humans address the kamuy: beside the hearth, at the sacred east window, at springs and riverbanks, on the mountain, and above all in the nusasan — the outdoor altar, a standing row of tall inaw that forms the kotan's permanent interface with the kamuy world, and beside which the honored skulls from sending ceremonies are kept. WHAT AN INAW DOES: The inaw is the universal offering and the universal messenger — the medium through which prayer travels and through which ramat (spirit) flows between the worlds. The kamuy are understood to prize inaw the way humans prize treasure: a kamuy who receives inaw is enriched by them in its own world. Each inaw carries the specific prayer spoken over it to the specific kamuy for whom it was made. Scholars have observed that the whole logic of the sending ceremonies treats the honored animal itself as functioning like a great inaw — a bridge across which grace flows between the kamuy world and the human one. THE FORMS: Inaw vary by purpose — different woods, lengths, and styles of shaving for different kamuy and occasions, from small hearth inaw to the great altar posts. The

knowledge of which form belongs to which use is part of the ceremonial literacy of the elders. THE IKUPASUY — A DISTINCT IMPLEMENT: Alongside the inaw, ceremony uses the ikupasuy — a flat, elegantly carved wooden wand often mistranslated as a 'mustache lifter.' Its real function is liturgical: during libations, the celebrant dips the tip of the ikupasuy into the wine and sprinkles drops to the kamuy, and the ikupasuy delivers the prayer with them — the carved patterns on the wand identifying and empowering the offering. The inaw carries the prayer to the kamuy's world; the ikupasuy delivers the offering at the moment of ceremony. Between them, they are the postal system of the tradition.

Part Eleven -- THE KAMUY NOMI: The General Sacred Ceremony — Step-by-Step

Kamuy nomi — literally 'praying to the kamuy,' pouring to the kamuy — is the generalpurpose sacred ceremony of the tradition: the form used to give thanks, to petition, to open an undertaking (a fishing season, a new house, a journey), or simply to maintain the relationship. Where the iyomante is the tradition's cathedral ceremony, the kamuy nomi is its daily liturgy, scalable from a single household hearth to a great public gathering. It remains the most commonly performed Ainu ceremony today, opening cultural events and community observances across Hokkaido. THE DAILY LAYER BENEATH IT: Ordinary practice needs no ceremony at all: thanks are spoken before eating; a few drops of drink are offered to the fire; Ape-huci is prayed to in times of sickness; a word is addressed to the water when drawing it and to the forest when entering it. The kamuy nomi is this everyday courtesy made formal. STEP 1 — PREPARATION: The celebrants (traditionally the elder men, in ceremonial robes) prepare the offerings: newly whittled inaw, and tonoto — the ceremonial wine, traditionally home-brewed from millet — together with food offerings. The hearth is tended; if outdoors, the ceremony is held before a nusasan altar. STEP 2 — THE FIRE FIRST: The first prayers always go to Ape-huci Kamuy, the fire grandmother — because she is the intermediary. She is greeted, thanked, given the first offerings, and asked to carry the ceremony's words to the kamuy being addressed. No kamuy nomi bypasses her; to skip the fire is to mail a letter with no carrier. STEP 3 — THE LIBATIONS: Seated before the fire or altar, the celebrants receive lacquered cups of tonoto. Each dips his ikupasuy into the wine and sprinkles drops toward the fire and the altar inaw, addressing each kamuy in turn by name — greeting, gratitude, and then the specific matter at hand — in the formal prayer register (kamuy itak, 'god language'). The order of address matters: fire first, then the kamuy of the occasion, then the supporting kamuy. STEP 4 — THE OFFERING OF INAW: New inaw are dedicated and planted — at the hearth, at the altar, or at the place of the occasion (a riverbank for a water ceremony, and in the contemporary Kamikawa observance, offered to the river itself). The inaw remain as the standing form of the prayer after the words have ended. STEP 5 — THE SHARED CUP: What the kamuy do not consume, the community does — the wine and food circulate, because eating and drinking in the kamuy's company completes the exchange. A kamuy nomi ends not in solemnity but in fellowship: songs, talk, the community warm around its fire. STEP 6 — THE CLOSING: Final thanks are spoken to the kamuy addressed and to the fire grandmother for her carriage of the words. The ceremony closes as it opened — with her.

Part Twelve -- YUKAR: The Sacred Epic Song Cycles

The Yukar is the central sacred literary and performative tradition of the Ainu — long epic song cycles that carry the sacred history, the cosmological knowledge, the relationships with specific kamuy, and the ethical teachings of the tradition in the form of narrative songs performed by specialists in specific ceremonial and communal contexts. The tradition is comparable in function to the oral epics of other cultures — the Homeric poems, the Finnish Kalevala, the West African griot repertoire — but with the specific sacred character of Ainu ceremonial life: yukar are not entertainment; they are the transmission vehicle for the tradition's most important knowledge, and their performance was understood as an act the

kamuy themselves attend and enjoy. THE GENRES: The oral literature divides into distinct genres. KAMUY YUKAR — the songs of the gods — are narrated in the first person by a kamuy itself: the owl god, the fox, the orca, the frog, the spirit of the damp earth, each telling its own story of its dealings with humans, each with its own signature refrain (sakehe). These are held to be the most ancient form in the repertoire, and were customarily sung by women. YUKAR proper — the heroic epics — are long narratives of human heroes, traditionally sung by men, though by the mid-twentieth century women bards had become the principal carriers of these too. The most celebrated hero is Poiyaunpe, the young champion raised in the fortress of Sinutapka, whose wars in defense of his homeland fill the great cycles — the epic Kutune Shirka (named for a treasured sword) is the most famous single example. The oyna genre carries the deeds of the culture hero Okikurmi / Aeoina Kamuy. UWEPEKER are prose tales — instructive stories of ordinary people and kamuy told in plain speech. And MENOKO YUKAR are epics with a woman at the center. (A sourcing note: an earlier compilation referred to a hero-cycle 'of Sinorikur'; that name could not be verified in the published literature and has been replaced here with the attested heroes and cycles.) THE WOMEN WHO SAVED THE ARCHIVE: In the crisis decades, when the language was banned from schools and the bards were dying, the tradition's survival came down largely to a handful of prodigiously learned women. Monashinouku, a bard born in 1848, carried the old repertoire; her daughter Imekanu (Japanese name Kannari Matsu) wrote out from memory, in romanized Ainu, notebook after notebook of epics — the Kannari Matsu Notebooks alone preserve over ninety yukar. And Imekanu's niece, Chiri Yukie (1903–1922), produced the tradition's foundational book: the Ainu Shin'yoshu, a collection of thirteen kamuy yukar — the songs of the owl god, the fox, the rabbit, the little wolf, the sea, the frog, the otter, the swamp mussel, the spirit of the damp earth — which she transcribed in romanized Ainu and translated into Japanese herself. She completed the manuscript in Tokyo in September 1922 and died of heart failure that same night, aged nineteen. Published in 1923, entirely under her own name, it was the first written collection of Ainu oral literature by an Ainu hand, and it remains the most important single source for the tradition. Her younger brother Chiri Mashiho became the great Ainu scholar of the language — and a sharp critic of the Japanese and Western ethnographers, including his sister's patron, the linguist Kindaichi Kyosuke, whose preservation work, however valuable, was framed by the colonial assumption that the Ainu were a 'dying race' to be archived rather than a living people to be supported. Both things are true at once: the transcriptions saved the epics, and the frame that funded the transcriptions was part of what was killing them. WHY IT MATTERS: A tradition without writing keeps its entire constitution — theology, law, history, ethics — in performed memory. The yukar are that constitution. When contemporary Ainu learners study the epics, they are not doing literary appreciation; they are re-installing the tradition's operating system.

Part Thirteen -- The Structure and Content of Yukar

THE SAKEHE — THE REFRAIN: Every kamuy yukar is built around its sakehe — a repeated refrain phrase unique to that song, returned to throughout the performance. The sakehe marks the verse structure, carries the melody, identifies the divine narrator (each god has its own), and creates the hypnotic, rocking repetition that carries both performer and audience into the story's frame of consciousness. It functions simultaneously as poetic architecture and as recurring invocation of the kamuy whose song it is. FIRST-PERSON DIVINITY: The defining formal feature of kamuy yukar is voice: the god narrates its own story. The owl god describes looking down on the village it guards; the fox describes its own misjudgment and its punishment; the orca tells of its gifts to the humans on the shore. The audience does not hear about the kamuy; for the duration of the song, the audience hears the kamuy. The formal closing phrases — 'thus the god sang of himself' — hand the voice back. THE CONTENT: The cycles encode the whole curriculum of the tradition: how the protocols were established (a kamuy mistreated by humans who withdrew its gifts; a kamuy honored who returned in abundance); the geography of the kamuy world; the origins of

ceremonies; the consequences of greed, disrespect, and broken reciprocity; and in the hero epics, the ethics of courage, loyalty, and the defense of the homeland across wars that plausibly preserve, in mythologized form, memories of real conflicts with neighboring peoples. THE METER AND THE STICK: Performance is rhythmic chant, the performer often marking time by tapping a stick (repni) against the hearth frame, the fixed meter and formulaic phrases serving — as in all the world's great oral epics — as the memory scaffolding that lets a bard hold tens of thousands of lines. The longest cycles run for many hours; full performances could span nights.

Part Fourteen -- THE YUKAR PERFORMANCE — Step-by-Step

PREPARATION: The performer prepares through focus and recollection — the cycle to be performed must be held complete in memory, and the performer settles into the concentrated attention the long chant requires. The setting is the hearth-side, the community gathered, the fire — as always — the first witness. STEP 1 — THE OPENING: The performance begins with the sakehe — the signature refrain of the cycle — announcing to the assembly which narrative, and which divine voice, is arriving. STEP 2 — THE NARRATIVE: The performer chants the story in the Ainu language, in the fixed rhythmic and melodic form belonging to that cycle. This is not free improvisation: it is the precise performance of a memorized text, within which a skilled bard varies pacing, emphasis, and vocal color according to traditional license. STEP 3 — THE REFRAINS: The sakehe returns throughout, holding the verse structure, resting the performer, and re-invoking the divine narrator with each return. STEP 4 — THE DURATION: Performances run long — hours for a substantial cycle, multiple sessions across multiple nights for the greatest epics. The duration is not an inconvenience; the sustained immersion is part of the sacred effect. STEP 5 — THE COMMUNITY'S PART: The assembly participates — marking the rhythm, responding at the refrains, receiving the knowledge. Listeners beat time with the performer; children absorb the language's highest register; the old correct the young afterward. The performance is the school. STEP 6 — THE CLOSING: The cycle ends with its formal closing phrases — the god's voice signing off, the narrative formally sealed — and the assembly returns from the story's world to the fire in front of them.

Part Fifteen -- Upopo: Communal Sacred Songs and Circular Singing

WHAT UPOPO ARE: Upopo are the communal songs — short, rhythmic, sung seated in groups, traditionally led by women, in ceremonial and festive settings. Where the yukar is a soloist's monument, the upopo is the community's own voice: simple phrases layered into complexity by the singing itself. THE ROUND TECHNIQUE: The signature upopo technique is circular, overlapping singing — one singer begins the phrase, the next enters before it ends, the parts chasing each other in canon around the circle, often with the singers beating rhythm on the lid of a treasure box (sintoko) between them. Sung well, the overlapping voices fuse into a shimmering, trance-tinged whole in which no single voice can be picked out — a musical image of the community itself. The women's vocal group Marewrew has carried this style to international audiences in the present day, and the national museum took its name from this practice: Upopoy means 'singing together in a large group.' REKUHKARA — THE THROAT GAME: The related paired practice of rekuhkara — two women face to face, one projecting voiced breath into the other's mouth cavity, which shapes and resonates it — parallels the throat-singing games of other northern peoples (most famously Inuit katajjaq). The Hokkaido practice died out in the twentieth century and is known from recordings and descriptions; revival attempts continue. RIMSE — THE DANCES: Upopo singing accompanies rimse, the circle dances — some depicting kamuy (the crane dance among the best known), some enacting work (sowing, pounding), some explicitly apotropaic, performed to frighten hostile spirits away with stamping and cries. The traditional Ainu dance repertoire is inscribed on UNESCO's Representative List of the

Intangible Cultural Heritage of Humanity, and dance troupes across Hokkaido perform and teach it today.

Part Sixteen -- The Mukkuri: Sacred Jaw Harp

THE INSTRUMENT: The mukkuri is a jaw harp of bamboo — a slender plaque, roughly palm-length, with a tongue cut free along its center. The player holds it to the mouth and sounds it not by plucking but by pulling: a cord attached to the frame is jerked sharply, setting the tongue vibrating, while the player's mouth cavity acts as the resonator. By changing the mouth's shape and breath, the player bends the buzzing fundamental into speech-like contours — wind through reeds, running water, animal and insect voices, whispered syllables. It was played chiefly by women, as an intimate instrument of the hearth-side rather than a concert instrument. **THE SOUND-WORLD:** The mukkuri's aesthetic is imitation and evocation of the living world — the instrument does not perform melodies about nature; it performs nature's own voices back to it. In a cosmology where every wind and stream is a kamuy, an instrument that speaks in their voices is not a toy. Mukkuri playing is among the most widely taught Ainu cultural skills today — workshops at Upopoy and community museums put the instrument into thousands of hands a year, making it one of the revival's most accessible doorways. **THE TONKORI:** The tradition's other signature instrument is the tonkori — a long, slender plucked zither of five (sometimes fewer or more) strings, associated especially with the Sakhalin Ainu, held against the body and played with both hands. Unfretted and tuned to open strings, it accompanies song and dance with rippling ostinato patterns. Nearly lost in the twentieth century, the tonkori was recovered from recordings and surviving instruments and has been carried back into performance — most visibly by the musician Oki Kano, whose Oki Dub Ainu Band has taken the instrument onto world stages. (A correction to an earlier compilation of this material, which described the mukkuri as a drum used by shamans: the mukkuri is a jaw harp. The drum as a shamanic instrument belongs to the Sakhalin Ainu healing tradition — see Part Eighteen.)

Part Seventeen -- Ainu Sacred Textiles: Attush and the Living Pattern

THE CLOTH: The classic Ainu robe is the attush, woven from the inner bark fiber of the elm — the bark stripped in spring, soaked, separated into fine threads, and woven on a simple tension loom into a strong, supple cloth. A second prestige fiber, retarpe ('the white thing'), was made from nettle by the Sakhalin Ainu; garments were also made from salmon skin, bird skin, and furs. When cotton arrived through trade with Japan, it was seized on eagerly, and the great appliqued cotton robes (kaparamip and related styles) joined the attush as ceremonial dress. **THE PATTERNS ARE PROTECTION:** Ainu robes are instantly recognizable by their bold, swirling, symmetrical patterns — and the patterns are not decoration. The core vocabulary — morew (the spiral), aiush (the thorn), sik (the eye) — is protective: thorns that snag evil, spirals that entangle it, eyes that watch for it. The patterns are concentrated exactly where a body is vulnerable — the neck opening, the front opening, the cuffs, the hem: every aperture of the garment guarded, so that nothing harmful can enter at the openings. A mother embroidering a robe was writing armor. **WHO MADE WHAT:** Textile arts belonged to women, and the patterns were a female literacy — taught from grandmother to granddaughter, sketched in hearth ash for practice, carried in memory like the yukar. Men's parallel art was carving: the makiri (knife) sheaths, the ikupasuy wands, the treasure vessels — their surfaces worked with the same protective vocabulary. Craft skill was courtship credential in both directions: a woman's embroidery and a man's carving announced their makers as marriageable adults. **SINUYE — THE WOMEN'S TATTOOS:** The tradition's most intimate protective art was tattooing — sinuye, 'to carve oneself.' Ainu women received tattoos in stages from childhood, most visibly the graceful curved marking around the lips, along with patterns on the hands and forearms, cut with a makiri and rubbed with birch soot, understood variously as beauty, as protection for the body's openings (the same logic

as the robes), as maturity marking, and as preparation for the passage to the next world. The Meiji government banned the practice in 1871 as part of the assimilation campaign — one of the first traditional practices formally prohibited — and by the later twentieth century living tattooed women were gone. Contemporary Ainu women artists, notably Mayunkiki, have made sinuye a subject of research and performance — re-performing the markings in paint as an act of reclamation, and forcing the question of what it means to recover a banned practice written on the body itself. THE LIVING PATTERN TODAY: Ainu textile arts are among the most vigorous branches of the revival: embroidery circles across Hokkaido, master weavers reconstructing attush technique, the patterns designated as Hokkaido Heritage, and contemporary designers carrying morew and aiush into new work — the armor still being written.

Part Eighteen -- Ainu Healing Traditions: The Tusu (Shaman/Diviner)

The tusu (the practice is tusu; the practitioner tusu kur, and in many communities most often a woman) is the Ainu shaman and diviner — the specialist who can directly perceive and communicate with the kamuy world, who diagnoses illness by identifying which kamuy has been offended or inadequately honored, and who conducts the healing work that restores right relationship. THE CALLING: The calling arrives; it is not chosen. It announces itself through illness that is recognized as the kamuy world's claim on the person, through dreams, or through the spontaneous onset of trance and second sight. The community's recognition — not self-appointment — confirmed a practitioner. GENDER AND THE TUSU: The role was held by both men and women, with female practitioners documented as particularly powerful in many communities — in Sakhalin Ainu tradition especially, shamanic healing was a developed institution with the drum (kaco) as its trance instrument, while Hokkaido practice centered on trance song and the hearth. A fairness note the modern record requires: the now-common Hokkaido claim that women should not pray to kamuy without male permission appears, on the historical evidence, to be a later development shaped by contact with patriarchal Japanese norms in the Edo period, not an original feature of the tradition — and the long suppression of shamanic practice has left many contemporary Ainu communities ambivalent about this whole branch of their inheritance. The healing tradition is the least revived part of the tradition, precisely because it was the most stigmatized. THE TRANCE STATE: In ceremony the tusu enters an altered state of consciousness — induced by rhythmic sound (song, and in the Sakhalin tradition the drum) and by the presence of the sacred implements — in which the kamuy speak through or to the practitioner. What returns from the trance is information: the cause, the offended party, the remedy, the message. THE WIDER MEDICINE CHEST: Shamanic diagnosis operated alongside a deep practical pharmacology. Ainu medicine drew on an extensive catalog of plant remedies — documented in the hundreds — from wound dressings and fever decoctions to the daily food-medicines: pukusa (wild garlic) and other gathered plants prized as both nourishment and protection, and plants whose strong smell was itself held to repel disease-bearing spirits. Healing in the tradition was thus two-layered: the herbalist's layer treating the body, and the tusu's layer treating the relationship whose breach the illness expressed.

Part Nineteen -- THE TUSU CEREMONY — Step-by-Step

OCCASION: The ceremony is called when someone is ill, when the community is experiencing disruption or misfortune, or when guidance from the kamuy world is needed and ordinary prayer has not sufficed. STEP 1 — PREPARATION: The tusu prepares through purification and through the assembly of the sacred implements the ceremony requires. STEP 2 — THE INAW: Prayer sticks are prepared and arranged — the standing prayers that will frame the working, each dedicated to the kamuy whose attention the ceremony seeks. STEP 3 — THE FIRE: Ape-huci, the fire grandmother, is addressed first, as always: the tusu

asks her to open the way and carry the ceremony's communications to the appropriate kamuy — and to protect the practitioner during the crossing. STEP 4 — THE TRANCE INDUCTION: The tusu begins the rhythmic singing (with the drum, in the Sakhalin tradition) that opens the trance — the rhythm and the song together loosening the practitioner's hold on the ordinary world and opening perception of the kamuy world. STEP 5 — THE COMMUNICATION: In trance, the tusu communicates with the kamuy concerned — identifying the cause of the illness or disruption (an offense, a neglected obligation, a hostile presence), receiving the remedy, and receiving whatever message the kamuy world wishes the community to hear. In the fullest form, the kamuy speaks through the practitioner, and those assembled hear the answer in the tusu's changed voice. STEP 6 — THE HEALING WORK: On the basis of what was learned, the healing actions are performed — prayers, offerings, the making of specific inaw, protective measures for the patient, or instructions the patient and household must carry out. STEP 7 — THE RETURN AND REPORT: The tusu returns from trance and reports plainly: the cause, the remedy, the message. STEP 8 — THE CLOSING: The ceremony closes with thanks — to the kamuy who answered, and to the fire grandmother who carried the words and guarded the door.

Part Twenty -- Death and Transition in Ainu Belief

THE PASSAGE: In Ainu belief the human spirit (ramat) is immortal. At death, the soul departs on a journey to the next world — and the doorway is the hearth: the soul passes through the fire of Ape-huci, the same grandmother through whom it arrived at birth, who now escorts it out. The destination in most accounts is the world of the dead — pokna mosir, the world below — pictured not as punishment but as a continuation: a land where the dead live much as the living do. Traditional belief also holds that the honored dead ascend to the kamuy world; the traditions vary by region, as oral traditions do, and the tradition itself treats detailed maps of the afterlife with reserve. THE FUNERAL: The dead were dressed in their finest ceremonial clothing and provided with grave goods — tools, vessels, treasured possessions — and the goods were deliberately broken or damaged before burial: an object must be 'killed' for its spirit to be released to accompany its owner, the same sending logic (iwakte) applied to worn-out tools. Prayers and offerings were made to the fire kamuy; formal verse laments were spoken, wishing the departed a smooth road; food and drink were offered. The grave was marked with a carved wooden post (kuwa) — differently shaped for men and women — and graves were placed away from the kotan and thereafter left alone: the Ainu did not maintain graves with repeated visits, because the dead had moved to their own country and excessive traffic between the countries was unwise. THE HOUSE-SENDING: In many communities, when the head of a household — in some regions specifically a woman — died, the house itself was burned after the funeral (kasa omante, the sending of the house), so that the dead would have their dwelling in the next world. A dead person is not homeless merely because they are dead; the tradition sends the architecture after the tenant. UNNATURAL DEATH: Death by disaster or violence was answered differently — including with formal speeches of protest addressed against the gods, the charanke register turned upward: grief expressed as remonstrance, the community demanding of the kamuy world an accounting for a death out of season. Even at the grave, the relationship remains one between persons who owe each other reasons. WHY THE REMAINS STRUGGLE MATTERS: All of this is why the modern history of grave-robbery for research (Part Twenty-Two) is experienced by Ainu communities as an ongoing spiritual injury, not a merely academic dispute. A tradition in which the dead were deliberately settled, provisioned, and left in peace had its cemeteries opened and its ancestors boxed in university storerooms. The demand for repatriation is, in the tradition's own terms, a demand to complete interrupted sendings.

Part Twenty-One -- Ainu Sacred Relationship with Salmon, Sea, and Forest

KAMUY CEP — THE FISH OF THE GODS: Salmon was the staff of Ainu life — called kamuy cep, 'the fish of the gods,' and sipe, 'the true food.' The autumn runs were caught in quantity, dried, and stored against the winter; salmon skin made boots and clothing; dried salmon was a principal trade good. The relationship was governed by ceremony and law alike: the first salmon of the run were received with the asir cep nomi — the newsalmon ceremony — welcoming the fish back and thanking the kamuy who sent them; specific customary rules (enforceable by charanke) governed who fished which waters, when, and by what means, including the marek, the hooked spear designed to take fish selectively. Rules of respect surrounded the whole harvest — care in how fish were taken, handled, and spoken of — because a rudely treated salmon reports home like any other guest. THE SEA: Coastal communities held their ceremonial relationship with Repun Kamuy, the orca lord of the open sea, master of its abundance. Whales driven ashore were the sea kamuy's deliberate gift and were received with ceremony. Sea hunting (seal, swordfish, and in some communities whales) and offshore fishing carried their own protocols and their own sending rites. THE FOREST AND THE COMMONS: The forests and river basins around each kotan formed its iwor — the community's territory of use, where members hunted (deer above all), gathered, and cut wood by right, under the customary rules. From the forest came the gathered staples: turep (the lily bulb whose starch was a storable staple), pukusa (wild garlic), butterbur, berries, bark for cloth and canoe, wood for inaw. The gathering economy was largely women's domain and women's expertise — a botany of hundreds of species held in memory. The forest was not scenery; it was the pantry, the pharmacy, the lumberyard, and the church. WHAT COLONIZATION DID TO ALL OF THIS: Meiji policy did not merely take Ainu land; it criminalized the Ainu food system. Salmon fishing in the rivers was banned as poaching. Deer hunting was restricted to protect settler agriculture. The commons became state forest. A people whose economy, diet, ceremony, and law all ran through the salmon run were legally severed from it within a generation — arguably the single most destructive act of the entire colonization, and the one whose repair is now being fought in court. THE SALMON RIGHTS STRUGGLE — RAPORO AINU NATION: In 2020 the Raporo Ainu Nation — the Ainu group of Urahoro, descendants of the kotan of the Tokachi River mouth — sued the national and Hokkaido governments for confirmation of their indigenous right to fish salmon commercially in their ancestral river, the first suit of its kind in Japan. International indigenous solidarity gathered around the case, including Sami and Haida leaders. On April 18, 2024, the Sapporo District Court ruled against them: it accepted the history — finding that the group's ancestors had fished those waters since at least the Edo period under binding Ainu custom, and that the Ainu right to practice their culture deserves respect 'as much as possible' — but held that no inherent right to commercial fishing exists in rivers deemed public property, and declined to treat UNDRIP as legally binding. The plaintiffs appealed to the Sapporo High Court; the ruling came two months after the death of the Nation's president, Masaki Sashima, who had led the fight. Meanwhile, communities such as the Monbetsu Ainu Association have turned the autumn salmon ceremony itself into standing protest — holding kamuy cep nomi at their rivers while the law still requires a governor's permission for an Ainu community to take salmon for its own ceremony from its own river. Under current practice, ceremonial catches are permitted by annual bureaucratic allotment; the inherent right remains unrecognized, and the litigation continues. THE ECOLOGICAL POINT: The tradition's rules — selective taking, seasonal restraint, ceremony that continually rehearses dependence and gratitude — constituted a working system of fisheries and forest management sustained for centuries. The sending ceremonies are, among everything else they are, a renewal technology: treat the animals as guests, and the guests keep coming.

Part Twenty-Two -- Contemporary Ainu: Revival and Recognition

THE COMMUNITY TODAY: Government surveys count roughly 13,000 Ainu in Hokkaido, with self-identification nationwide commonly put around 25,000 and the true number of people with Ainu ancestry believed to be far higher — concealment being itself a legacy of

discrimination. Substantial Ainu communities live in Tokyo and other cities, to which many moved in the later twentieth century for work and to escape Hokkaido's sharper prejudice. The Ainu Association of Hokkaido remains the largest representative organization; a new generation of smaller, more assertive groups — the Raporo Ainu Nation and others organized as kotan-descended collectives — now leads the rights litigation. THE LANGUAGE: Ainu is critically endangered — native fluent speakers are now nearly gone, with estimates in the single digits — but the learner community is real and growing: community classes across Hokkaido, radio language programs, university courses, archives of recordings, and a young generation of activist-learners raising the language's public presence. The trajectory has turned from silent decline to contested revival; whether it reaches new native speakers is the open question of the next generation. THE CEREMONIES: The iyomante ban-notice was withdrawn in 2007; kamuy nomi opens public events across Hokkaido; the first-salmon ceremonies are held (and contested) at the rivers; the dances are on UNESCO's intangible heritage list; and Upopoy, the National Ainu Museum and Park at Shiraoi (opened July 2020), anchors a network of community museums — Nibutani, Akan, and others — where ceremony, craft, music, and language are taught. THE ARGUMENTS AROUND UPOPOY: Upopoy is both achievement and controversy. Critics within and beyond the Ainu community charge that it presents culture without adequately presenting colonization — heritage display without historical accounting — and that its memorial facility embodies the sharpest grievance of all: the ancestral remains. From the nineteenth century onward, researchers opened Ainu graves and took the dead; more than 1,600 sets of ancestral remains accumulated in Japanese universities (Hokkaido University above all), with others scattered internationally. Rather than returning them to their communities, the state consolidated unclaimed remains at a memorial site at Upopoy — a 'solution' many Ainu regard as continuing the offense. Litigation, begun against universities in the 1980s and repeatedly settled, entered a new phase in May 2026, when the Sibechari Ainu group filed the first suit against the national government itself, demanding the return of 279 ancestral remains from Upopoy on the argument that Ainu tradition vests authority over the dead in the kotan, not the state. THE POLITICAL WEATHER: The 2019 recognition did not end denialism. Hate speech denying Ainu existence circulates online; in 2026 a national party leader publicly rejected Ainu indigenous status, and a Sapporo municipal venue approved a panel exhibit asserting the Ainu are not indigenous — met with protest and formal statements from scholarly associations condemning both the remains situation and anti-Ainu hate speech. Recognition, in other words, is a front in an ongoing argument, not a settled fact of Japanese public life. Against this backdrop, 2025 brought three significant institutional acknowledgments: in September, Tokyo University issued an official apology to the Ainu people for its historical role in the removal of ancestral remains from Ainu communities, accompanying the repatriation of 35 sets of remains to Ainu in Otaru; in December, three major academic societies — the Japanese Society of Cultural Anthropology, the Japanese Archaeological Association, and the Anthropological Society of Nippon — issued formal public statements condemning anti-Ainu hate speech, with two simultaneously delivering apologies for the excesses of past academic research. And in August 2025, a new advocacy organization, the Ainu Mosir no Kai (MIP Movement), was established with the goal of negotiating for Ainu land, resource, and cultural rights through direct dialogue and, if necessary, litigation — building on the template of the Raporo case. THE CULTURAL RESURGENCE: Against that weather, the revival is unmistakable: Ainu musicians (the tonkori of Oki Kano, the upopo of Marewrew) on world stages; Ainu artists (Mayunkiki and others) in international biennales; Ainu writers, designers, and chefs; and — with enormous popular reach — the manga and anime Golden Kamuy, created with Ainu cultural supervision, which put Ainu language, food, belief, and material culture in front of tens of millions of readers and measurably boosted public interest in, and respect for, Ainu culture across Japan. The people Japan nearly erased are now among the most visible indigenous cultures in Asia. THE HONEST SUMMARY: Fifteen thousand years of presence; one hundred and fifty years of attempted erasure; fifty years of organized resistance; a generation of revival. The kamuy nomi is performed in public again. The language is being learned again.

The courts are being made to read the old customary law. What the tradition calls charanke — the long, formal, unyielding argument — is being conducted with the Japanese state itself, and it is not over.

Part Twenty-Three -- The Haligrity Lens: Kamuy and the Sacred Presence in All Things

The Ainu tradition offers Haligrity one of the most immediate and most operationally specific available ancient expressions of the understanding that the divine is not separate from the natural world but present within it as the interior sacred dimension of every being — what the Ainu call kamuy and what Haligrity holds as the foundational cosmological reality. KAMUY AND THE HALIGRIC LIVING WORLD: When the Ainu speak directly to the bear before the iyomante — thanking it for visiting, expressing love for the kamuy who has spent years in the community's care, requesting that the kamuy tell the other kamuy that this community is worthy of more visits — they are doing what the Haligrity tradition holds as the foundation of sacred relationship: acknowledging the divine presence in the other being, maintaining the specific relationship that makes the divine world's blessings flow into the human community, and doing so with the specific combination of love and protocol that sacred relationship requires. The fire is not a fire. The fire is the grandmother who carries prayers to the kamuy world. Never insult her. Never step over her. When you speak to her before sleeping, she carries what you said upward. The bear is not a bear. The bear is a divine being who came to visit in a body, bringing meat and fur and relationship. When you send the bear home — carefully, lovingly, with gifts and prayer and gratitude and the specific request to tell the others — you are maintaining the relationship that makes the kamuy world want to visit again. This is not mythology. This is the operating principle of a sacred relationship with the living world that the Ainu have maintained for fifteen thousand years. Grand Rising.

Closing -- The Kamuy Are Still Present

"The bear is a kamuy who came to visit. We raised it with love. We send it home with gifts. We ask it to tell the others that we are worthy. They will come again." — On the Ainu Iyomante and the sacred logic of the bear sending ceremony. Japan legally recognized the Ainu as an indigenous people in 2019. The Upopoy National Ainu Museum opened in Hokkaido in 2020. The Iyomante was suppressed for a century and condemned by official notice in 1955; the notice was withdrawn in 2007, and the ceremony is practiced openly again. The Yukar are being taught to a new generation of Ainu learners. The Ainu language — a language isolate with no known relatives — is being learned by community members who grew up speaking only Japanese. The salmon ceremonies are held at the rivers while the courts hear the old law argued anew. Fifteen thousand years of continuous presence in the northern islands of Japan. The kamuy are still present. The fire grandmother still carries prayers. Grand Rising.

In 2025, a new rights issue emerged: surveys for potential permanent nuclear waste storage sites in the Hokkaido towns of Suttu and Kamoenai proceeded without consultation with the Ainu, whose ancestral territory covers the entirety of Hokkaido. Ainu activist Fumio Kimura stated that "any nuclear waste on our land is horrible and our right to the land shouldn't be neglected." Ann-Elise Lewallen, professor at the University of Victoria specializing in Indigenous and environmental rights, called the process "energy colonialism." The matter of free, prior, and informed consent regarding nuclear energy and waste disposal on Hokkaido became a major active rights issue in 2025 under UNDRIP standards. In October 2025, the Ainu held the 10th International Jew's Harp Congress in Japan, drawing attention to worldwide similarities in musical culture reflected in this Indigenous instrument. On November 26, 2025, Ainu musician and artist Oki Kano received the Japan Association of Audiovisual Producers' Excellence in Planning Award for his documentary "Ainu in Everyday

Attire" about the life of a Hokkaido Ainu family. The nuclear waste issue, the salmon fishing rights litigation, and the ongoing repatriation of ancestral remains all remained active as of 2025-2026. The Upopoy National Ainu Museum (Poroto Kotan), opened in 2020, continues as the institutional center of the public-facing Ainu revival.